



POL 2057: Introduction to International Relations

Fall 2025

Class times: **MWF 10:30am – 11:20am**

Locations: All in-person classes will meet at **Prescott Hall Rm 132**

Instructor: **Dr. Rachel Van Nostrand**

rvannostrand@lsu.edu

Office hours: MW 2:00-3:00 p.m.* (213 Stubbs Hall)

**Or by appointment/Zoom – email to schedule*

Teaching Assistant (Last names A-J): **Maia Raoux**

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Teaching Assistant (Last names (K-Z): **Megan Bass**

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Overview and Course Objectives

This course introduces students to the study of international relations. No prior background in the subject is assumed. Students will acquire the basic analytic tools necessary to understand and explain a variety of international phenomena including war, terrorism, trade, foreign investment, globalization, environmental cooperation, human rights practices, migration and the movement of refugees. By the end of the semester, students should be able to contribute objectively to debates on these topics and to provide theoretically-informed and empirically-valid evidence in support of their claims. In addition to the regular materials of a class of this kind, students will also work on developing policy writing skills to aid in the dissemination of their ideas.

Student Learning Outcomes

By the end of the semester:

- You will be able to describe traditional theoretical explanations for international relations;
- You will be able to interrogate the validity of hypotheses and arguments about international relations;
- You will have developed writing skills to help communicate arguments and evidence to a policy audience.

- You will identify the approaches and methodologies of Social Scientists, using evidence to critically analyze questions and arguments, and consider contributions of this perspective to finding solutions to global and/or local challenges.
- You will demonstrate competency in working with numerical information by critically analyzing quantitative information, generating ideas that are supported by quantitative evidence, assessing the relevance of data and its associated implications in a variety of contexts, and communicating those ideas and/or associated interpretations using various formats (graphs, data tables, equations, oral presentations, or written reflections).

Course Materials

The textbook for this course is Jeffry A. Frieden, David A. Lake, Kenneth A. Schultz, *World Politics: Interests, Interactions, and Institutions*, Fifth Edition (New York: W.W. Norton, 2021). This is identified below as “**FLS**”.

IMPORTANT NOTE: You need to purchase access to the online quizzes on Norton, even if you do not purchase a physical textbook. You can buy online access to the textbook AND the quizzes for around \$50 (which is much cheaper than buying a new textbook). If you only want access to the quizzes, it only costs \$25 for the whole semester. You can do a 21-day trial to access the textbook and quizzes. You might want to do this if you decide to drop the class later.

Links to purchase online textbook and quiz access here:

<https://wwnorton.com/books/World-Politics/>

Some students prefer to buy a used textbook and buy access to the quizzes separately. If you find an older edition of the textbook for cheaper, it will probably be fine, especially if you are doing the quizzes alongside it and attending lectures. **However, if you buy a used textbook it will not come with access to the online quizzes! This needs to be purchased separately.**

Course materials and links to quizzes are being delivered digitally via Moodle. Please access the material through Moodle on the first day of class to make sure that there are no issues with delivery so any problems can be addressed quickly.

Schedule of Topics and Readings

Week 1

- Monday 25th August: **Introduction and Logistics**
- Wednesday 27th August: **Lessons from History**
- Friday 29th August: **Lessons from History**

1. Review the syllabus (this document)
2. Read FLS Introduction and Chapter 1
3. After class, please complete the “Chapter 00” and “Chapter 01” InQuizitive quizzes. These should be completed before 11:59pm on Sunday at the end of the week (August 31st)
 - ***Note: Please be in touch with your TA IMMEDIATELY if your grades do not sync on Moodle***

Week 2

- Monday 1st September: **NO CLASS – Labor Day**
- Wednesday 3rd September: **Lessons from History**
- Friday 5th September: **Interests, interactions, & institutions**

1. Read FLS chapter 2
2. After class, please complete the “Chapter 02” InQuizitive quiz (due 9/7)

Week 3

- Monday 8th September: **Interests, interactions, & institutions**
- Wednesday 10th September: **Geography**
- Friday 12th September: **The Causes of War**

1. Read FLS chapter 3
2. After class, please complete the “Chapter 03” InQuizitive quiz (due 9/14)
3. Please submit the stage 1 writing assignment by the end of the day (11:59pm) on **Friday 12th September 2025**. Please submit via Moodle (**5% toward your final grade**).

Week 4

- Monday 15th September: **The Causes of War**
- Wednesday 17th September: **The Causes of War**
- Friday 19th September: **Domestic politics and war**

1. Read FLS chapter 4
2. After class, please complete the “Chapter 04” InQuizitive quiz (due 9/21)

Week 5

- Monday 22nd September: **Domestic politics and war**

- Wednesday 24th September: **Domestic politics and war**
- Friday 26th September: **NO CLASS – Instructor at Conference**

1. Read FLS chapter 5
2. After class, please complete the “Chapter 05” InQuizitive quiz (due 9/28)

Week 6

- Monday 29th September: **International institutions and war**
- Wednesday 1st October: **International institutions and war**
- Friday 3rd October: **International institutions and war**

1. Read FLS chapter 6
2. After class, please complete the “Chapter 06” InQuizitive quiz (due date: 10/5)
3. Please submit the stage 2 writing assignment by the end of the day (11:59pm) on **Friday 3rd October 2025**. Please submit via Moodle (**10% toward your final grade**).

Week 7

- Monday 6th October: **Civil Wars and Terrorism**
- Wednesday 8th October: **Civil Wars and Terrorism**
- Friday 10th October – **Civil Wars and Terrorism**

1. Read FLS chapter 7
2. After class, please complete the “Chapter 07” InQuizitive quiz (due 10/12)

Week 8

- Monday 13th October: **Midterm Review**
- Wednesday 15th October: **Midterm Exam (In class)**
- Friday 17th October: **NO CLASS – Fall Break**

Week 9

- Monday 20th October: **International Trade**
- Wednesday 22nd October: **International Trade**
- Friday 24th October: **International Trade**

1. Read FLS chapter 9
2. After class, please complete the “Chapter 09” InQuizitive quiz (due 10/26)

Week 10

- Monday 27th October: **Monetary Policy**
- Wednesday 29th October: **Monetary Policy**
- Friday 31st October: **Monetary Policy**

1. Read FLS chapter 10
2. After class, please complete the “Chapter 10” InQuizitive quiz (due 11/2)
3. Please submit the stage 3 writing assignment by the end of the day (11:59pm) on **Friday 31st October 2025**. Please submit via Moodle (**10% toward your final grade**).

Week 11

- Monday 3rd November: **Poverty and Development**
- Wednesday 5th November: **Poverty and Development**
- Friday 7th November: **Poverty and Development**

1. Read FLS chapter 11
2. After class, please complete the ‘Chapter 11’ InQuizitive quiz (due 11/9)

Week 12

- Monday 10th November: **International norms**
- Wednesday 12th November: **NO CLASS – Instructor at Conference**
- Friday 14th November: **NO CLASS – Instructor at Conference**

1. Read FLS chapter 12
2. After class, please complete the “Chapter 12” InQuizitive quiz (due 11/16)

Week 13

- Monday 17th November: **International norms**
- Wednesday 19th November: **Human rights**
- Friday 21st November **Human rights**

1. Read FLS chapter 13
2. After class, please complete the “Chapter 13” InQuizitive quiz (due 11/23)
3. Please submit the stage 4 writing assignment by the end of the day (11:59pm) on **Friday 21st November 2025**. Please submit via Moodle (**15% toward your final grade**).

Week 14

- Monday 24th November: **Protecting the environment**
- Wednesday 26th November: **NO CLASS – Thanksgiving Break**
- Friday 28th November: **NO CLASS – Thanksgiving Break**

Week 15

- Monday 1st December: **Protecting the environment**
- Wednesday 3rd December: **Global Order and Refugees**
- Friday 5th December: **Global Order and Refugees**

1. Read FLS chapter 14
2. After class, please complete the “Chapter 14” InQuizitive quiz (due 12/2)

Week 16

- Monday 8th December: **Final Exam (12:30-2:30 p.m.)**

Grades and Assignments

A breakdown of final grade calculations is as follows:

Attendance and Participation = 5%
Weekly InQuizitive quizzes = 10%
Writing assignments = 45%
Midterm Exam = 20%
Final Exam = 20%

The grade distribution for the course is as follows:

A+: 97-100; **A**: 93-96.9; **A-**: 90-92.9
B+: 87-89.9; **B**: 83-86.9; **B-**: 80-82.9
C+: 77-79.9; **C**: 73-76.9; **C-**: 70-72.9
D+: 67-69.9; **D**: 63-66.9; **D-**: 60-62.9
E = 59.9 and below

Requests for incomplete (I) or withdrawal (W) must be made in accordance with University policies.

Attendance and In-Class Participation (5%)

We will be completing taking attendance at random during this course, which will often be associated with an in-class discussion or activity. Attendance will not be announced beforehand and will not be taken every class. Those with medical excuses or official excuses due to participation in school-sanctioned activities should get in touch with their TA.

Weekly completion of InQuizitive quizzes (10%)

You are asked to complete what are called “InQuizitive” quizzes on a weekly basis. There are a total of 14 of these quizzes. They are all conveniently linked through Moodle. These quizzes serve two important functions in this class. First, they will help you to ensure that you are keeping up with and understanding the materials of the class. Second, these quizzes will serve as excellent preparation for the midterm and final exam in this class. This should be completed each week by the end of the day on Sunday at the end of the week (unless noted

otherwise in the syllabus). You can keep answering questions until you get to 100%.

Signature written assignments (45%)

You are asked to complete a series of four cumulating written assignments across the course of the semester. These will collectively form the “signature assignment” in the class.

1. Identify Topic (5%)

- a. In the first part, you are asked to identify a topic in international relations (e.g., any of the substantive issues addressed in the syllabus) in which you have some interest. This could include anything related to war, human rights, international political economy, poverty and development, terrorism, etc. Checking recent news stories from places like BBC can be a great way to identify an ongoing issue in international relations. Further suggestions are available on Moodle for ways to choose a topic. Please reach out to your TA if you are unsure of what to choose. You will write on this topic throughout the semester, so be sure it is something you are interested in.
- b. In this first part you should submit a single page document in which you (a) identify the topic of your assignments, (b) characterize the nature of the problem at the heart of the topic that makes it difficult for countries to solve, and (c) discuss specifically how the problem relates to your own life or the experiences of your community. Basically - tell us why you care about this issue. This first part is worth **5%** of your grade in the class. Your 1-page assignment should be submitted to Moodle by the end of the day on **Friday 12th September, 2025**.

2. Identifying Sources (Annotated Bibliography) (10%)

- a. In the second part, you are asked to identify three existing sources that address the nature of the problem at the heart of your topic of interest. Your goal is to find three sources which help you to understand the problem, and start to identify potential solutions.
- b. The three sources **MUST** include 1) an academic journal article, 2) a piece of reputable journalism and 3) a report from a government agency, think tank, or non-profit.
- c. For each source, you must provide details on 1) what the article says, and how it helps you to better understand your issue, 2) what kinds of solutions that article might point towards or support, 3) how you identified and found the article (i.e. keywords used, what search engines you relied on), and 4) why you trust this source or found it reputable.

- d. The second part is worth **10%** of your grade in the class and should be submitted to Moodle by the end of the day on **Friday 3rd October, 2025**.

3. Finding Data (10%)

- a. In the third part, you are asked to find two pieces of data which help to illuminate the issue and/or point to a solution. These could be graphs, tables, or maps. For each piece of data, you should tell me 1) where the data is from, and why you feel like you can trust it 2) explain the graphic and the data included within it 3) explain how that data is helpful for illuminating the problem and/or potential solutions.
- b. These data should NOT be drawn from the three sources you used in the previous assignment.
- c. This third part is worth **10%** of your grade in the class. Your 2-page assignment should be submitted to Moodle by the end of the day on **Friday 31st October, 2025**.

4. Writing the Op-Ed (20%)

- a. In the final part, you are asked to write an op-ed essay. You are asked to present a possible solution to the problem you have identified, and convince the reader that the solution you have identified is the best possible option. You will need to explain why other alternative solutions would not work. Good papers will also be sure to present the pros and cons of the solution they are arguing for.
- b. You should write your own essay and focus upon a substantive topic detailed in the 16 weeks of this class (see schedule). You can find details on the style and structure of writing an op-ed here: <https://journalistsresource.org/tip-sheets/writing/how-to-write-an-op-ed-or-column>
- c. You are allowed to use all the previous sources to build your final essay (this includes the three sources and the two data sources). You may NOT, however, just copy what you wrote for those assignments. You will need a total of seven sources. This means you need two sources in addition to those from previous assignments.
- d. The op-ed should be approximately 1000 words in length. Though the length is short, your goal is to write something DENSE and PERSUASIVE.
- e. This final part is worth **20%** of your grade in the class. Your 2-page (minimum) op-ed should be submitted to Moodle by the end of the day on **Friday 21st November, 2025**.

Midterm Exam (20%)

This exam will be completed in class on **Wednesday 15th October, 2025**. The exam will cover materials from Weeks 1 through 7. No make-up exams will be

permitted unless you have a Dean's excuse or full medical notification to excuse a delay. Please get in contact with me asap if alternative arrangements need to be made for official university activities.

Final Exam (20%)

This exam will be completed in class (same classroom) on **Monday 8th December, 2025, from 12:30-2:30 p.m.** The exam will cover all materials from weeks 1 through 15, inclusive, though will focus more intensely on materials from the second half of the course. No make-up exams will be permitted unless you have a Dean's excuse or full medical notification to excuse a delay.

Important Information

Expectations

LSU's general policy states that for each credit hour, you (the student) should plan to spend at least two hours working on course related activities outside of class. Since this course is for three credit hours, you should expect to spend a minimum of six hours outside of class each week working on assignments for this course. [Visit the LSU Catalog](#) for more information regarding general information for courses.

LSU Student Code of Conduct

The LSU student code of conduct explains student rights and what is expected of student behavior. Students are expected to understand this code as described on the [Code of Conduct page](#). Any violations of the LSU student code will be duly reported to the Dean of Students.

Plagiarism

Students are encouraged to share intellectual views and discuss freely the principles and applications of course materials. However, graded work/exercises must be the product of independent effort unless otherwise instructed. Students are expected to adhere to the LSU Code of Academic Integrity as described in the LSU Code of Student Conduct. See full code of conduct here: <https://www.lsu.edu/saa/students/codeofconduct.php>

As a student at LSU, it is your responsibility to refrain from plagiarizing the academic property of another person and to utilize appropriate citation method for all coursework. In this class, it is recommended that you use the American Political Science Association format for citations, but any consistent citation style (i.e. Chicago), is fine. Please see <https://owl.english.purdue.edu> or <https://guides.lib.lsu.edu/citation/plagiarism> for assistance.

One tool available to assist you in correct in-text citations is the “References” function in Microsoft Word. This program automatically formats the information you input according to the citation method you select for the document. This program also has the ability to generate a reference or works cited page for your document. The version of Microsoft Word with the “References” function is available through LSU Tigerware.

I take academic integrity violations very seriously. Plagiarism and cheating of any sort will not be tolerated. The first such incidence will be met with a failing grade (zero points) for the assignment, and any subsequent violation will result in a failing grade for the course. Any violation of academic integrity will be reported immediately to the dean's office, and they reserve the right to administer additional sanctions on top of my rules.

The instructor holds the copyright to their lectures and course materials, including student notes or summaries that substantially reflect them. Student notes and course recordings are for individual use or for shared use on an individual basis. Selling class notes and/or other course materials to other students or to a third party for resale is not permitted without the instructor's express written consent. Violations to the instructor's copyright are subject to the Code of Academic Integrity and may result in course sanctions. Additionally, students who use Moodle or their LSU email to sell or buy these copyrighted materials are subject to Code of Conduct Violations for misuse of student email addresses.

Use of Artificial Intelligence

As a partner in your learning, it is important to both of us that any assignment submission is a pure reflection of your work and understanding. The introduction of artificial intelligence options to complete academic work jeopardizes my ability to evaluate your understanding of our course content and robs you of the ability to master the subject matter. The instructor does not use artificial intelligence (AI)/large language model (LLM) tools in the creation of course content or teaching materials.

In this course, any and all uses of generative artificial intelligence (AI)/large language model tools such as ChatGPT, Dall-e, Google Bard, Microsoft Bing, etc. (not exhaustive list) will be considered a violation of the Code of Academic Integrity (above), specifically the prohibition against submitting work that is not your own. This applies to all assessments in the course, including any written assignments, discussions, quizzes, exams, etc. This course policy is driven by the learning goals and desired learning outcomes for the course: critical thinking, discussion, and interpretation of research. AI/LLMs are unable to foster these learning outcomes in their current form.

The following actions are prohibited:

1. entering all or any part of an assignment statement or test questions as part of a prompt to a large language model AI tool;
2. incorporating any part of an AI-written response in an assignment;
3. using AI to summarize or contextualize reading assignments or source materials; and
4. submitting your own work for this class to a large language model AI tool for iteration or improvement.

Suspicious of the use of AI programs in academic work will be reported to Student Advocacy & Accountability for review under the Code of Student Conduct and may result in impacts to your assignment and/or course grades. I reserve the right to meet with students about submitted assignments that are suspected of being AI generated or plagiarized, or requesting significant revisions to submitted assignments.

Disabilities

Louisiana State University is committed to providing reasonable accommodations for all persons with disabilities. The syllabus is available in alternate formats upon request.

Students with disabilities: If you are seeking classroom accommodations under the Americans with Disabilities Act, you are required to register with Disability Services in 124 Johnston Hall. Their phone number is 225-578-5919 and website is www.lsu.edu/disability. To receive academic accommodations for this class, please obtain the proper Disability Services forms and meet with me at the beginning of the semester.

Academic Success

The primary ingredients of your academic success are attending class, managing your time efficiently, taking good notes, and developing good critical thinking and communication abilities. LSU has a number of excellent resources that will assist you in developing these skills. The place to begin is the [**Center for Academic Success**](#) (CAS). The CAS offers guidance on what learning strategies are best suited to your talents, tutoring in the basic subjects, and workshops on a variety of topics, from note taking to time management. [**Communication Across the Curriculum**](#) assist students in developing the communication skills necessary for academic and professional success. Finally, with respect to professional success, the [**LSU Olinde Career Center**](#) can assist you in choosing a major and a profession that best suits your talents and passions and help you develop a four year career plan to ensure success when you graduate from LSU.

Diversity, Equity & Inclusion Statement

We believe diversity, equity, and inclusion enrich the educational experience of our students, faculty, and staff, and are necessary to prepare all people to thrive

personally and professionally in a global society. Therefore, LSU is firmly committed to an environment that affords respect to all members of our community. We will work to eliminate barriers that any members of our community experience.

To make LSU a place where that can happen, we must recognize and reflect on the inglorious aspects of our history. We now acknowledge the need to confront the ways racism, sexism, ableism, ageism, classism, LGBTQ+ phobia, intolerance based on religion or on national origin, and all forms of bias and exploitation have shaped our everyday lives.

We accept personal and professional responsibility to eliminate bias and oppression wherever they are found. We understand our obligation to speak up when we see bias whether it be in our teaching, study, or daily work. Our community will educate themselves proactively and continuously about how to intervene and bring bias to the attention of others with commitment and compassion.

We will hold ourselves accountable for our actions and inactions, and for maintaining intentional, measurable, and meaningful efforts to enhance diversity, equity, and inclusion, including through ongoing evaluation of our policies, practices, and procedures.

Nondiscrimination, Sexual Harassment, & Title IX

LSU provides equal opportunity for all qualified persons in admission to, participation in, or employment in the programs and activities which the university operates without regard to race, creed, color, marital status, sexual orientation, gender identity, gender expression, religion, sex, national origin, age, mental or physical disability, or veteran's status. LSU has implemented a procedure to address complaints for those who believe they have been subjected to discrimination and/or harassment in violation of this policy. Please know that your instructors are here to support you and listen to your experience. We also want you to know that we are mandatory reporters and must report what we know to the Office of Civil Rights and Title IX. All LSU employees, with few exceptions, are required to report instances of sex- or gender-based harassment and discrimination, including sexual misconduct and power-based violence (e.g., sexual assault, stalking, dating violence, domestic violence, sexual exploitation, retaliation, etc.) for which they may not be the victim, but of which they are aware.

The Office of Civil Rights & Title IX is the LSU office responsible for investigating complaints regarding any type of discrimination, sexual harassment, or power-based violence. The Office of Civil Rights & Title IX is located in 118 Himes Hall and the phone number is 225-578-9000. If you are aware of an individual who has been victimized, you are encouraged to contact the Office of Civil Rights &

Title IX or file an online report by visiting [LSU's Title IX](#) website and clicking the [Report an Incident](#) box. If you have been assaulted, harassed, or a victim of violence, we encourage you to contact the Office of Civil Rights & Title IX. Please reach out for help immediately. Some excellent resources available to Baton Rouge residents include:

- STAR (Sexual Trauma Awareness and Response; 24/7 hotline: 855-435-STAR (7827)
- IRIS Domestic Violence Center; 24/7 hotline: 800-541-9706
- The Lighthouse Program; 225-578-5718
- VIA LINK; 800-273-TALK (8255) [national line but answered from New Orleans]

National resources include:

- RAINN (Rape, Abuse & Incest National Network); 24/7 hotline: 800-656-4673
- National Sexual Violence Resource Center

For additional information, visit www.lsu.edu/civil-rights the [Office of Civil Rights & Title IX](#) and review [PM-73](#) (Prohibiting Power-based Violence, including Sex- and Gender-based Harassment and Discrimination, and Sexual Misconduct).

ILC Statement

Integrated learning allows students to make simple connections among ideas and experiences and across disciplines and perspectives. The LSU Integrative Learning Core (ILC) curriculum is designed to develop student abilities to transfer their learning to new situations, and demonstrate a sense of self as a learner. A fundamental goal of the ILC is to foster students' practical and intellectual capacities associated with integrative learning in preparation for high competence and functionality in their post-baccalaureate careers. This course fulfills the BOR Area of *Social/Behavioral Sciences* and provides students experience with the ILC proficiency of *Global Learning*.

Subject to Change Statement

Information contained in the course syllabus, other than the grade and absence policy, may be subject to change with advance notice, as deemed appropriate by the instructor.